

Our Two Cents - App Summary

Evidence source: repository files in backend/, dashboard/, docs/, and top-level README.

What It Is

Our Two Cents is a WhatsApp-first budgeting app with a companion web dashboard. Users log spends by message, while the backend stores and calculates budget data in Google Sheets.

Who It Is For

Primary persona: couples tracking shared spending and saving toward a house deposit (explicitly stated in README and reflected in user/goal flows).

What It Does

- Accepts WhatsApp commands to log spends and parse category, amount, and merchant.
- Sends bot replies for help, categories, goal progress, undo, and budget feedback.
- Stores data in Google Sheets tabs: Transactions, Monthly Budgets, Savings Goal, Categories.
- Calculates monthly totals, per-category status, warning levels, and days left in month.
- Exposes dashboard API endpoints for overview, categories, transactions, and goals.
- Provides a React dashboard with phase-gated views, category filtering, and quick WhatsApp actions.

How It Works (Architecture, Repo-Backed)

- Core components: React + Vite dashboard (dashboard/src), Express API server (backend/server.js), Twilio messaging service, Google Sheets service.
- Data flow A: User -> WhatsApp -> Twilio webhook -> /webhook/whatsapp route -> parser/budget/sheets services -> Google Sheets -> Twilio reply.
- Data flow B: Dashboard UI -> axios client (dashboard/src/services/api.ts) -> /api/dashboard routes -> budget/sheets services -> Google Sheets -> JSON to UI.
- Configuration comes from .env files (ports, Twilio credentials, Google credentials, phase, dashboard token).
- Dashboard route authentication enforcement in server wiring: Not found in repo (auth middleware exists in backend/middleware/auth.js but is not applied in backend/server.js).

How To Run (Minimal)

- Install deps: ``cd backend && npm install`; then `cd ../dashboard && npm install``.
- Create env files: copy backend/.env.example and dashboard/.env.example, then set required values (Google Sheet + service account, Twilio credentials, phone numbers, dashboard token, API URL).
- Start apps: backend ``npm run dev`` (port 3000), dashboard ``npm run dev`` (Vite local URL).
- For WhatsApp end-to-end testing, run ngrok and set Twilio sandbox webhook to ``/webhook/whatsapp``.
- Production backend/frontend URLs: Not found in repo.